

50501 Chapter Affiliation Program

A Framework for Legal Affiliation, Financial Access, and Movement Continuity

Introduction

The 50501 movement was never born in a boardroom. It didn't come from political consultants or corporate foundations. It emerged from a place of urgency — from artists, organizers, students, parents, and everyday people who had simply had enough. What began as a call to action became a code of resistance, showing what decentralized power could achieve when rooted in love, outrage, and collective care.

Now, in a moment where fascism grows bolder and grassroots movements face increasing digital, legal, and reputational threats, it is critical that we protect what we've built. That protection cannot come at the cost of grassroots freedom — but it also cannot exist without structure, transparency, and coordination.

50501 Inc. was created to offer that structure without erasing the soul of the movement. As the federally registered nonprofit steward of the 50501 identities, we exist to protect its legal footprint, stabilize its infrastructure, and distribute the tools needed for real-world impact. Our incorporation in Virginia, registration in Washington D.C., and official filing with the IRS allow us to offer shared legal protections, centralized support, and brand legitimacy without imposing centralized control.

The 50501 Chapter Affiliation Program is a formal pathway for local, state, regional, and identity-based organizing bodies to become recognized chapters within the 50501 ecosystems. It enables organizers to legally operate under the 50501 name and gain access to critical resources including donation platforms, debit card disbursements, event infrastructure, and digital tools — all without requiring chapters to incorporate individually or sacrifice their autonomy.

This program is not about command. It is about coordination. It is about making sure that chapters are not left exposed, underfunded, or isolated while doing frontline work.

Through a simple vetting process, a values-based MOU, and a commitment to collective integrity, chapters can join the movement as full, protected partners in a growing nationwide network.

50501 Inc. is here to serve, not control.

We are here to ensure that the flame organizers lit together never burns out due to disorganization, liability risk, or political sabotage.

And we are here to say that the movement — decentralized, defiant, and unshakably grassroots — is ready to move forward with protection, power, and permanence.

Chapter Affiliation Overview

The 50501 Chapter Affiliation Program offers a structured yet flexible pathway for grassroots organizers to gain official recognition, resources, and protection under the 50501 movement without losing their autonomy or local identity. This program is designed to empower decentralized organizing bodies while reducing the legal, financial, and infrastructural burden typically associated with formal nonprofit incorporation.

Through a simple application and vetting process, qualifying chapters will become officially affiliated with 50501 Inc., a federally registered 501(c)(4) nonprofit entity. Once approved, chapters will gain access to a broad range of strategic, legal, and material benefits to ensure their success, credibility, and protection.

Affiliated Chapters Will Be Able To:

- Operate publicly and legally under the 50501 name, logo, and brand identity. Chapters will be granted a license to use the 50501 name and associated assets (including the tagline: “50 protests. 50 states. 1 movement.”) in connection with their organizing activities, events, social media presence, and communications, provided they adhere to the movement’s mission and standards.
- Receive donations through ActBlue with chapter-specific fundraising links. 50501 Inc. will create dedicated ActBlue donation pages for each affiliated chapter, allowing them to fundraise independently while operating under the umbrella of a recognized 501(c)(4). This ensures legal compliance and donor confidence while minimizing administrative overhead.
- Access and manage funds through prepaid debit cards tied to their individual accounts. Chapters will be issued debit cards, allowing for transparent, accountable, and real-time access to their own fundraising revenue. Funds raised by each chapter remain with that chapter — no funds are pooled or redistributed without consent.
- Obtain logistical, legal, and digital support from 50501 Inc. Affiliated chapters will receive access to:
 - Protest permitting templates and guidance
 - Event insurance resources (where available)
 - Technical support for event coordination and communications
 - Legal documents for risk mitigation and volunteer waivers
 - Branding assets and sign templates for public use
 - Onboarding into secure communication platforms such as Signal, ProtonMail, and secure cloud storage
- Retain full autonomy in decision-making, event planning, and local campaigns. Affiliation with 50501 Inc. does not impose any top-down directives. Chapters will continue to govern their own priorities, leadership, and organizing strategies. National support will be advisory, not authoritative.

Legal & Structural Notes

Affiliated chapters are not required to incorporate as separate legal entities or seek 501(c)(4) status individually. By operating under the registered structure of 50501 Inc., they benefit from:

- Legal protection and liability shielding for organizing activities
- Centralized IRS compliance for fundraising and public transparency
- Elimination of state-level nonprofit registration and annual reporting requirements
- Clear ownership and permission for use of the 50501 name, trademarks, and communications infrastructure

This arrangement allows grassroots leaders to focus on action — not paperwork.

Chapter Benefits

Affiliating with 50501 Inc. grants chapters access to a comprehensive suite of structural, financial, legal, and strategic support tools — all while preserving grassroots autonomy. These benefits are designed to reduce administrative barriers, increase chapter resilience, and elevate the work of local organizers through national-level infrastructure and protection.

1. Legal Use of the 50501 Brand

- **Trademark-Authorized Affiliation:**
Approved chapters receive formal permission to operate publicly under the 50501 name, tagline, and branding elements. This includes full legal access to the federally registered trademarks:
 - “50501” (USPTO Serial No. 99122369)
 - “50 protests. 50 states. 1 movement.” (USPTO Serial No. 99122956)
- **Brand Protection and Public Legitimacy:**
Chapters benefit from being part of a legally recognized, protected national organization. Misuse of the brand will be actively monitored and enforced by 50501 Inc. to ensure your chapter’s reputation is not undermined by bad actors.

2. Chapter-Specific Fundraising Infrastructure

- **Dedicated ActBlue Fundraising Page:**
Each chapter will receive a uniquely linked ActBlue donation page, hosted and maintained under the 50501 Inc. umbrella. Donations raised via these pages go directly to the chapter that raised them — not to national or pooled funds.
- **Chapter-Only Debit Card Access:**
Each chapter will be issued a secure, prepaid debit card tied to their fundraising account. These cards allow for quick access to funds, simplified tracking of expenses, and real-time reporting — all while maintaining independence from national administration.

- **Financial Transparency and Control:**
Chapters retain full control over how their funds are used within a set of approved spending categories (e.g., supplies, printing, transportation, accessibility tools). No chapter funds will ever be redirected without consent.

3. Digital Infrastructure Support

- **Toolkits and Hosting Resources:**
Access to digital assets such as:
 - Organizing templates and downloadable toolkits
 - Web and email hosting options (custom@50501us.org email addresses available)
 - Shared design resources including logos, graphics, and signage templates
- **Cybersecurity & Communications:**
Chapters will receive guidance and optional onboarding into encrypted tools such as:
 - Signal (for secure group messaging)
 - ProtonMail or Microsoft 365 (for email and storage)
 - Secure cloud-based storage and internal directories
- **OpSec Best Practices:**
National experts will offer regular trainings on operational security (OpSec), digital footprint reduction, risk management, and how to protect volunteer data and organizing plans.

4. Legal and Logistical Guidance

- **Protest and Action Templates:**
Chapters will receive a library of legal templates and checklists for:
 - Permit applications and legal notifications
 - Liability waivers and safety disclaimers
 - Protest coordination protocols
- **Registered Agent and Compliance Aid:**
For chapters seeking greater formality, 50501 Inc. can offer guidance or direct assistance with:
 - Obtaining a registered agent in your state
 - Structuring internal roles (chair, treasurer, etc.)
 - Understanding IRS reporting requirements for 501(c)(4) actions
- **Emergency Legal Support Pathways:**
In the event of protest-related incidents, affiliated chapters may receive direct assistance or referral to civil rights attorneys, legal observers, or crisis response professionals.

5. Peer Collaboration and Support

- **National Organizer Community:**
Chapters will be onboarded into the broader network of 50501 affiliates, where they can build relationships, share tactics, and collaborate across state lines.

- **Movement-Building Opportunities:**
Affiliated chapters will be invited to:
 - Monthly national strategy calls
 - Special topic workshops (digital security, media training, etc.)
 - Campaign coordination for national days of action, boycotts, mutual aid, and issue-based rapid responses
- **Cross-Chapter Solidarity:**
Support other chapters through joint fundraisers, media campaigns, and cross-posted endorsements — amplifying local struggles with national reach.

Affiliation Requirements

To maintain the integrity and consistency of the 50501 movement across all regions, chapters seeking official affiliation with 50501 Inc. must complete a simple, but important, onboarding process. This process ensures that each chapter is truly aligned with the mission, values, and decentralized structure of the national movement — while also preserving autonomy and grassroots identity.

1. Chapter Affiliation Form Submission

- **Initial Intake:**
Organizing groups must complete the official 50501 Chapter Affiliation Form, available through the secure 50501us.org website. This form collects essential details such as:
 - Chapter name and region or identity-based focus
 - Names and contact information for key organizers
 - Mission statement or organizing focus
 - Previous events, campaigns, or community involvement
- **Purpose of Submission:**
This is not a test or gatekeeping tool — it's a way for national to ensure legitimacy, reduce impersonation, and connect chapters to relevant resources. No organizing experience is “too small” for participation; what matters is commitment and alignment.

2. Verification Call

- **Onboarding Call or Meeting:**
Once the application is reviewed, a short verification call will be scheduled with 50501's chapter onboarding team. The goal of this session is to:
 - Confirm the authenticity of your chapter or group
 - Answer any questions about the benefits or expectations of affiliation
 - Establish direct contact with your chapter for future communications
 - Begin building relationships rooted in mutual support and transparency
- **Timing & Flexibility:**
Calls are typically 20–30 minutes and can be conducted via phone, Zoom, or Signal — whatever is most secure and accessible for your team.

3. Memorandum of Understanding (MOU)

- **Formal Affiliation Agreement:**
Chapters will be asked to sign a legally sound Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) that outlines the scope of the partnership. The MOU includes:
 - Your rights to use the 50501 name and branding under trademark law
 - The protections you receive from 50501 Inc. (legal, digital, financial)
 - Your agreement to uphold the core principles of the movement
 - Procedures for disengagement, transition, or internal conflict
- **Not a Contract of Control:**
The MOU is not designed to micromanage chapters — it's meant to protect your organizing, clarify expectations, and legally shield you from external threats while respecting your independence.

4. Ongoing Adherence to Organizational Values

- **Core Principles of Affiliation:**
By affiliating with 50501 Inc., each chapter agrees to uphold the following shared values:
 - Transparency – Honest reporting, open communication, and accountability
 - Inclusivity – A commitment to anti-racism, anti-ableism, queer liberation, and the centering of marginalized voices
 - Nonviolence – A principled approach to resistance and disruption that avoids harm to people or communities
 - Grassroots Decentralization – A refusal to replicate top-down structures, corporate hierarchies, or political gatekeeping
- **Autonomy Preserved, Values Aligned:**
While every chapter will pursue different local strategies and styles, all are expected to maintain a commitment to the movement's deeper purpose: building people-powered resistance that is compassionate, principled, and unapologetically inclusive.

Limitations and Restrictions

The following are strictly prohibited under the Chapter Affiliation Program:

- Independent financial fundraising under the 50501 name outside of the approved ActBlue system
- Use of 50501 branding for partisan political campaigns, endorsements, or personal gain
- Retention of funds without accountability or misappropriation of donor resources
- Misrepresentation of non-affiliated events as official 50501 initiatives
- Engagement in harassment, discrimination, exclusionary behavior, or gatekeeping
- Public or internal disparagement of other 50501 chapters, leadership, or structural decisions

Violations may result in termination of chapter affiliation, brand enforcement actions, and revocation of digital access.

Legal Standing

To protect both the decentralized grassroots identity of 50501 and the legal and financial integrity of its operations, all approved chapters shall operate under the umbrella of 50501 Inc., a federally recognized nonprofit organization formed under the following legal framework:

- **Incorporation:**
50501 Inc. is incorporated as a nonprofit domestic corporation in the Commonwealth of Virginia and is duly registered as a foreign nonprofit entity in the District of Columbia.
- **IRS Compliance & Intent to Operate:**
50501 Inc. has formally filed a Notice of Intent to Operate as a 501(c)(4) social welfare organization with the Internal Revenue Service (IRS), placing it under the federal rules governing advocacy-based nonprofit activity. The organization maintains active and lawful compliance with both federal and state requirements for nonprofit operations.

Unified Legal Framework for Chapters

All affiliated chapters — including state-based, city-based, regional, or identity-based groups — are considered extensions of 50501 Inc.’s federal legal identity and benefit from its structure and protections. This provides:

- **Trademark Protection:**
Chapters may publicly and legally operate under the “50501” name and associated branding, protected by federal trademark registration (USPTO Serial Nos. 99122369 and 99122956).
- **Liability Shielding:**
Through the central incorporation of 50501 Inc., affiliated chapters are offered a buffer from individual legal exposure, particularly in contexts of lawful protest, organizing, or communications.
- **Centralized Risk Management:**
Insurance options, legal documentation templates, and coordinated compliance efforts reduce legal vulnerability and simplify chapter operations.

No Need for Separate Incorporation

Chapters are not required to incorporate independently or apply for their own federal tax-exempt status. This is intentional — to minimize administrative burden and make it easier for new organizers, students, local volunteers, and grassroots collectives to participate fully in the movement without legal or financial barriers.

However:

- Chapters must act in good faith under the guiding principles, policies, and MOU provisions set forth by 50501 Inc.
- Activities that compromise the legal integrity, insurance eligibility, nonprofit protections, or tax-exempt standing of 50501 Inc. may result in removal from the affiliation program, suspension of privileges, or legal enforcement under applicable civil and nonprofit statutes.

Optional Independent Incorporation

Should an affiliated chapter desire or require its own 501(c)(4) status or incorporation (e.g., for regional grants, contracts, or long-term organizational scaling), it may do so — but will be subject to additional review. In such cases:

- The chapter must disclose the intended structure and purpose of its entity
- A secondary MOU or affiliation agreement will be required to govern shared branding, legal relationships, and fundraising channels
- The chapter must remain in alignment with 50501 Inc.'s values and may not use the 50501 brands in contradiction to national policy

This allows growth and self-determination without compromising the legal or ethical framework that protects the movement.

Application Process

50501 Inc. welcomes grassroots organizing bodies of all sizes and backgrounds to apply for official chapter status under the national legal and nonprofit structure. The application process is designed to be accessible and transparent, while also ensuring that affiliated chapters share a commitment to the movement's founding principles of justice, equity, inclusivity, and decentralized leadership.

Affiliation is open to:

- Statewide organizing collectives
- City or municipal grassroots networks
- Regional coalitions
- Identity-based advocacy groups (e.g., LGBTQIA+, youth-led, disabled activists, BIPOC-led chapters, etc.)

Organizers do not need to be incorporated or have existing nonprofit status. However, each applicant must demonstrate a clear and ongoing commitment to nonviolent activism, democratic values, and solidarity with the larger 50501 ecosystem.

Required Materials

All prospective chapters must submit the following:

1. Completed Chapter Affiliation Application Form
 - This form includes fields for chapter leadership, organizing history, social media (if applicable), communication preferences, and current infrastructure needs.
 - The form also captures information related to safety protocols, organizing style, and values alignment.
2. Letter of Intent or Chapter Mission Statement
 - A brief written narrative (1–2 pages preferred) that outlines the chapter's vision, local context, and alignment with the 50501 movement's values.
 - This is your chapter's opportunity to describe how you build community, act, and plan to uphold shared principles of inclusivity, transparency, and people-powered organizing.
3. Signed Memorandum of Understanding (MOU)
 - Upon preliminary approval, all applicants will be issued an official MOU outlining legal use of the 50501 brand, shared responsibilities, and mutual protections.
 - Final onboarding is contingent upon the return of a fully signed MOU.

Review and Approval Timeline

All applications are reviewed on a rolling basis by 50501 Inc.'s national chapter support team, which includes peer organizers from existing chapters.

- Initial screening typically occurs within 3–5 business days of receipt.
- If additional information is required, the chapter will be contacted promptly.
- Final determinations are issued within 7 business days of submission of a complete application package and any requested clarifications.

Once approved, chapters will:

- Be formally onboarded via a welcome packet and optional video onboarding session
- Receive immediate access to digital resources and a custom ActBlue fundraising page
- Be issued a debit card tied to their fundraising account, if requested
- Receive verified public recognition as an official 50501 chapter

Where to Submit

To begin the application process, send your application materials to:

Email: chapters@50501us.org

Subject Line: 50501 Chapter Application – [Insert Chapter Name or Region]

For example: 50501 Chapter Application – Seattle or 50501 Chapter Application – Queer
Midwestern Youth

We believe in building a national movement through shared power, not centralized control. The affiliation process is not meant to gatekeep, but to protect — and ensure that every chapter has the legal, logistical, and financial support it needs to thrive and resist.

Let me know if you'd like to add sections on Disaffiliation Procedures, Chapter Vetting Criteria, or Organizing Safety Protocols.

Conclusion

The 50501 Chapter Affiliation Program exists to protect what made this movement powerful in the first place: people. Organizers. Survivors. Students. Workers. Parents. Artists. Activists. Everyday individuals who chose to rise in defense of democracy, civil rights, and community dignity — without waiting for permission.

What began as an unfiltered call to action across 50 states now demands the structure to last. Not to control it — but to defend it.

This program was built with a singular purpose:
To ensure that no chapter ever must choose between organizing boldly and protecting itself legally.

Too many grassroots movements collapse not because they lack energy or purpose — but because they lack protection. When infrastructure is missing, vulnerability fills the void. When transparency is absent, confusion grows. When legal protections are denied, good people bear the consequences.

50501 Inc. is committed to rewriting that story.

By offering this affiliation program, we're not asking chapters to give up their identity — we're offering them a shield. A toolkit. A foundation. A real chance to build locally while being part of something nationally recognized, respected, and resilient.

Affiliation means access — not oversight.
It means connection — not control.
It means standing together — not falling alone.

We understand the risks of organizing in this moment.
We understand the exhaustion. The fear. The rage.
And we are here — not just to say we see you, but to ensure you are never isolated again.

If you are building power in your community, we want to support it. If you are pushing back against injustice, we want to help protect it. And if you're ready to take the next step with us, this is your invitation.

Let's keep 50501 in the hands of the people who gave it life — and build a future none of us can be shut out of.